

### **Notes 3 - Types of Workplace Hazards**

**Hazard:** A hazard is anything that has the potential to induce harm or other adverse effects. People can experience health effects, while organizations can experience property or equipment loss.

Hazards can also present the potential for harm to the environment.

**Harm:** The term “harm” refers to the adverse effects posed by hazards. Picture a slippery floor that has been left wet after cleaning. The slippery floor is a hazard, but harm only occurs when the slippery floor has caused negative health effects to a human or equipment damage or damage to the environment.

In short, a hazard is the potential source of harm to a worker. Harm is the actual negative outcome, such as an injury or damage to the affected worker.

#### **Types of Workplace Hazard:**

**Biological:** Biological hazards include bacteria, insects, viruses, plants, animals, birds, humans, etc., that can cause adverse health impacts. For example: harmful plants, sewage, dust and other bodily fluids.

**Chemical:** Chemical hazards are hazardous substances that can cause harm. These hazards can result in both health and physical impacts, such as skin irritation, respiratory system irritation, blindness, corrosion and explosions.

**Physical:** Physical hazards are environmental factors that can harm an employee without necessarily touching them, including loud noises, extreme pressures, magnetic fields, radiation, fire, poor lighting, unsafe machinery, misused machinery, obstructions in walkways, slippery floors, etc.

**Safety:** These are hazards that create unsafe working conditions. For example, equipment malfunctions, equipment breakdowns, inappropriate machine guarding, tripping and slipping hazards, etc. Exposed wires or a damaged carpet might result in a tripping hazard.

**Ergonomic:** Ergonomic hazards are a result of physical factors that can result in musculoskeletal injuries. For example, poor equipment design, improper workstation setup, heavy or awkward lifting, repetitive movements, etc.

**Psychosocial:** Psychosocial hazards include those that can have an adverse effect on an employee’s mental health or wellbeing. For example, violence, stress, constant low-level noise, threats of danger, discrimination, harassment, public relations, intense workloads, shift work, etc.